PORTLAND PUBLIC SCHOOLS

To: Board of Directors
From: Dr. Kimberlee Armstrong, Superintendent
Dr. Jon Franco, Senior Chief of Operations
Margaret Calvert, Assistant Superintendent, Planning & Modernization

CC: Deborah Kafoury, Chief of Staff

Date: December 4, 2025

Subject: **Jefferson Dual Assignment Scenario Recommendation**

The recommendation that follows provides the path to grow and stabilize enrollment at Jefferson High School, restoring it to a vibrant, high demand school rooted in community, culture and excellence while also sustaining robust programming at the neighboring high schools. Sunsetting the Jefferson dual assignment zone will ensure comparable access, enrollment clarity, and long-term stability for students and schools across North/Northeast Portland. This recommendation demonstrates our commitment to providing students, particularly students who have been historically underserved, well-resourced learning environments close to where they live. It is emblematic of the purposeful actions and strategic investment needed to transform our system so that students have commensurate access to academic programming and learning environments where they can flourish and demonstrate their excellence.

Connection to Board Goals

The Board's direction for increasing enrollment at Jefferson High School is grounded in its commitment to commensurate access, rigorous academics, and improved outcomes for all students—particularly Black students who were most impacted by the historical changes to Jefferson and the Albina neighborhood, as well as all students who have been historically underserved. Aligned to the PPS Board Goals for graduation and the district's vision for every student to experience a four-year path toward college and career readiness, this work is centered on creating the conditions where Jefferson students can thrive. Strengthening Jefferson's academic programming, stabilizing enrollment, and investing in a safe, modernized school environment are essential to implementing the instructional strategies, culturally responsive supports, and robust coursework that enable students to meet the Board's expectations for on-time graduation and postsecondary success. This effort reflects the district's responsibility to design learning environments where every student—especially those most impacted by past inequities—has access to the opportunities, relationships, and high-quality instruction that lead to strong outcomes.

Related Policies/Best Practices

I. 4.10.045-P Student Assignment to Neighborhood Schools
II. 4.10.051-P Student Enrollment and Transfers

Background

In December 2022, the Portland Public Schools (PPS) Board of Education adopted resolution 6627, which stated that "By the start of the 2026-27 school year, the Superintendent will initiate a process to develop a plan to increase student enrollment at Jefferson High School."

Jefferson High School has a long and storied history in PPS. It is the only high school in Oregon to have had a majority Black student population, many of whom were residents of the Albina community. Gentrification and urban renewal efforts significantly transformed Albina and nearby neighborhoods. Beginning in the 1980s, Jefferson students were allowed to transfer to other PPS schools, first through a voluntary desegregation program and then, in the early 2000s, through the federal No Child Left Behind program. Jefferson enrollment declined substantially, and the school was reorganized into several small schools.

In 2011, the PPS Board of Education converted Jefferson to a Middle College for Advanced Studies focus option as part of a district-wide high school system redesign. The Middle College built upon existing partnerships with Portland Community College and Self Enhancement, Inc to create opportunities for students to earn up to 45 credits at Portland Community College, along with the academic and social support to prepare for college success. In light of these distinct features, the Board, through resolution 4394, created dual assignment zones allowing Jefferson neighborhood students to have a guaranteed option at either the Middle College focus option or a nearby comprehensive high school.

Since the implementation of the dual assignment zones, Jefferson enrollment has ranged from 440-670 students. Over that same period, the comprehensive high schools that receive dual assignment students have seen significant enrollment growth, spurred, in part, by campus modernizations completed at Roosevelt (2017), Grant (2019) and McDaniel (2021). With the 2024 completion of Benson and Alliance, Jefferson is now the only non-modernized high school in North/Northeast Portland.

In May, 2025, Portland voters approved funding for the full modernization of Jefferson High School. Construction planning is underway, and groundbreaking for campus improvements will occur in Spring 2026. PPS recognizes the need to revitalize Jefferson enrollment in order to ensure comparable access to quality education within the community, optimize resource allocation, and support the successful implementation of Jefferson's modernization plan. In June, 2025, Superintendent Armstrong informed the Board that she would bring forward a recommendation to sunset the dual assignment option during the 2025-26 school year.

Superintendent's Recommendation

The Superintendent recommends that Scenario C is implemented starting in the fall of 2027-28 with the incoming ninth grade class and to be fully phased in 2030-31 school year. Staff used the six factors identified in policy 4.10.045 that contribute to optimal school boundaries, our PPS racial equity lens, and community feedback to arrive at this recommendation.

This scenario provides a path for all four high schools to have student enrollment that is

projected to meet the minimum for stable academic programming and ranges between them that will increase programming parity. All historically underserved students will have access to comparable academic programming to their peers across the city. This scenario also assigns the vast majority of students who live within a mile of a high school to the closest school. The timeline provides stability and access to academic programming for current students, as well as future students at Jefferson and time for thoughtful implementation. The scenario also provides manageable enrollment changes across the schools that will be coordinated and planned with district and school staff.

This scenario will require investment in additional staff at Jefferson to support the sequenced and intentional expansion of programs. It will also require focused attention on Right of Return to continue to offer choice for families that have been displaced from the Jefferson attendance area. Enrollment across all schools will need to be monitored regularly, with continued attention to Roosevelt due to its relative geographic isolation. The demographics of the student population at Jefferson will change the most as this plan is implemented. As was highlighted when the scenarios were assessed with our racial equity lens, it is critical that staff purposefully work with current Jefferson students to elevate their voices, sustain the school culture, and identify their needs.

As a result of the community feedback regarding the need for another measure of proximity, we created additional maps to highlight the density of student populations that are within 1.0 and 1.5 miles of each of the four high schools. In addition, we worked with staff from Secondary Academics and Jefferson administrators to outline a timeline, process and framework for expanding the academic offerings at Jefferson to provide both breadth and depth of courses that build on the strengths of current programming as it transitions from a focus option to a comprehensive high school.

Summary of Scenario C performance on Key Performance Indicators and factors:

Factor	Analysis Metric or Description	Scenario C
A feeder pattern that allows as many students as possible to continue together from one school level to the next.	Percent of middle school students moving to the same high school (KPI)	Seven of the ten elementary feeders move together to high school.
Student body demographics	Percent of Black/Native American and multi-lingual learners at high schools with enrollment of greater than 1100	All four high schools achieve enrollment of greater than 1100 in 2030-31. 100%

Factor	Analysis Metric or Description	Scenario C
Compact boundaries that promote safer routes to schools and a sense of community as well as recognize and address natural and human-made barriers	Addressed in two ways: transit analysis and maps of students who live within 1.0 and 1.5 miles of the high school	Students living in the three areas where walking times are shorter than transit times are assigned to the closest high school. (Boise-Eliot/Humboldt and Chief Joseph to Jefferson and Irvington to Grant.) Irvington has a significant portion of its attendance area that is within a mile of Grant.
Optimal use of existing facilities	Description of utilizations for all high schools in 2030-31.	All four high schools will have projected utilization rates between 70% and 90% in 2030-31.
Program and enrollment stability in the surrounding schools	Two Key Performance Indicators: Percent of schools that have enrollment greater than 1100 in 2030-31 and Range of enrollment across the high schools in 2030-31 of 350 students or less.	All four high schools are projected to have enrollment of at least 1100, with Roosevelt closest to 1100 at 1153. The range is estimated to be 371 students.
Limiting the impact of boundary changes to the smallest number of students possible	All students in the dual assignment zone will be impacted.	

Fiscal Impact

Staffing schools is based on enrollment, and allocations will follow the students as they are assigned to neighborhood and program-based schools. Most likely, there will not be significant operational staffing costs as changes are made for the region. There will be initial costs to develop the Career Technical Education and elective pathways with the incremental increase of enrollment at Jefferson. There will be an investment of at least 2 FTE during the phase in years starting in the fall of 2026 and ending in the spring of 2030 to support the growth of academic programming and a budget will be allocated for training and staff development for additional programs.

Timeline for Implementation

The staff recommends that boundary and feeder pattern changes follow the phase-in process described in policy 4.10.045-P starting in the 2027-28 school year. This will bring student changes one year at a time as middle school students transition to high school in their freshmen year. It allows students guaranteed transfer to their former neighborhood school after a boundary change if an older sibling is attending there.

The implementation impacts by school and year can be found here. To prepare for the changes central office teams, including human resources, facilities, school modernization, enrollment and transfer, secondary academics, special education, family and community engagement, community partnerships will support the school teams in smooth transition of planning for the enrollment changes across the four high schools.

Academic Programming At Jefferson

We worked with staff from Secondary Academics and Jefferson administrators to outline a timeline, process and framework for expanding the academic offerings at Jefferson as it transitions from a focus option to a comprehensive high school. This emerging vision represents a starting point for engagement with key stakeholders, with final decisions shaped through collaboration with students, families, staff and partners. It focuses on four academic pillars: college preparatory coursework, career and technical education pathways, visual and performing arts, and a rich partner-supported learning ecosystem.

Two examples of programming options that could be considered are outlined for informational purposes. One possibility includes creating universal course offerings at the sophomore level in core content areas such as AP seminar for English Language Arts (ELA). This mirrors the dual credit junior ELA course that is currently in place at Jefferson. A second possibility builds on the historic arts legacy at Jefferson while incorporating contemporary creative industries. For example, this may include a sequenced pathway in dance, music and theater with audio engineering or costume and apparel design. The modernization effort provides a unique opportunity to plan and build learning spaces to house forward-looking CTE pathways.

The planning and engagement opportunities will build on existing structures such as site council, PTSA, and school leadership teams with additional outreach to middle grade students and families. These efforts outlined below also align with the annual school forecasting and schedule building process.

- **Winter 2025-26 (December - February) - Focus: Course Offerings 2026-27**
  In addition to the regularly scheduled meetings with site council and PTSA, staff will hold a Visual and Performing Arts engagement session with students, families, staff and community artists to inform expanded arts pathways. Launch Partner Engagement to clarify roles in pathways and curriculum alignment. For middle school and high school students, interpret YouScience Data to help students identify broad aptitude and interests in CTE programs and follow up with family nights. Identify any potential programmatic shifts for the 2026-27 school year for example, sophomore AP seminar for ELA.

- **Spring 2026 (April - May) - Focus: CTE and Middle School Transition Activities**
  Identify two or three priority pathways for CTE by synthesizing feedback into a short list of promising early pathways for feasibility review. Modernization-dependent ideas are named but reserved for later planning. District CTE, Office of School Modernization, and Jefferson leadership assess staffing, facilities, sequencing, and partner needs for each recommended pathway. Findings are shared back with stakeholders for refinement. Community check in on pathway recommendations for the 2027-28 school year. Middle school students visit the Jefferson campus to take part in transition activities.
- **Summer 2026 (June - August) - Focus: Staff Development and Partner Engagement**
  Professional learning to support new academic pathways and planning for CTE course outlines. Confirm commitments and roles for PCC, PSU, OHSU, community-based organizations, and industry partners.
- **Fall 2026 (September - November) Focus: Family Orientation and Programming Launch**
  Hold orientation sessions for families regarding new academic pathways and elective offerings. Gather early feedback from students, staff, and families on implementation of new programs and make adjustments to the planning cycle. Report progress to PPS Leadership.
- **Winter 2026-27 Focus: Course Offerings 2027-28**
  Staff follow up with a Visual and Performing Arts engagement session with students, families, staff and community artists to inform expanded arts pathways and check on progress. Partner Engagement to review roles in pathways and curriculum alignment and check on progress. Identify any potential programmatic shifts for the 2027-28. Regular updates will be provided to the site council and PTSA through their standard meeting rhythms.

Review of dual language immersion feeder pathways and other enrollment reviews will be incorporated into subsequent rightsizing processes which will begin in the Spring of 2026.

Further information can be found in the Options with analysis and Community engagement summary found in the attachments.

The Superintendent recommends that Scenario C is implemented starting in the fall of 2027-28 with the incoming ninth grade class and to be fully phased in during the 2030-31 school year. The proposed attendance zones can be seen on this map and reflect the following:

- Beach Spanish DLI and Peninsula feed to Roosevelt High School
- Irvington feeds to Grant High School
- All Other Feeder Programs to Jefferson High School

ATTACHMENTS

A. Board Information Item - increasing enrollment at Jefferson
B. Resolution 6627 December 2022
C. Resolution 4394 January 2011
D. Map Students with 1.5 Miles Grant
E. Map HS Students within 1.5 Miles Jefferson
F. Map HS Students within 1.5 Miles McDaniel
G. Map HS Students within 1.5 Miles N/NE High Schools
H. Map HS Students within 1.5 Miles Roosevelt
I. Enrollment Scenario Summary
J. Transit Analysis
K. Superintendent's recommendation, summary, and student demographics
L. Options with analysis
M. Community engagement summary
N. Superintendent's recommendation attendance zone map
O. Jefferson Dual Assignment Map By Race and Ethnicity (with school boundaries)
P. Timeline of outreach
Q. Final community engagement analysis